



2017 Examiners' Report

Practical Papers

This report highlights the key observations of the Examiners to provide information and help for those who sat the 2017 Masters of Wine Examination as well as guidance for future candidates. The videos of the Exam feedback interviews are published on the Institute's website and candidates are encouraged to watch the recording. It is a valuable addition to this report. Each section has been written by the Panel Chair of the respective panel of Examiners, and draws on the detailed comments made by the individual Examiners assessing the papers. Without prejudice, this report is delivered for information purposes only, and may not be relied upon by individual candidates with reference to their particular Examination papers.

Practical Panel Chair Report

Philip Tuck MW

Introduction

As ever, this report tries to summarise the most important observations, both positive and negative, of the MW practical examination team, and should be considered in conjunction with both the feedback video on the MW website and the “MW Practical Examination Guidelines for Students”. Additionally, Peter Marks MW, a very experienced recent examiner, who has taken on the role of Education Committee Practical Chair, has made some salient observations having moderated the Stage 1 Assessment this year.

Of the 140 students who sat the exam in 2017, only 14 did enough to pass which is down considerably on 2016. Hearty congratulations to those successful candidates from all the examination team. Your scripts were a delight to read and showed the necessary accuracy and authority to convince us of your excellent tasting. As I mentioned last year, I always worry that we have set an exam that varies in difficulty from one year to the next. This year I felt that Paper 1 was perhaps the toughest and this was indeed reflected in the marks. It should be remembered though that for every challenging question, there will be a correspondingly straightforward question and the examiners are mindful of this.

General Observations

Now that I have written this report a number of times, I can't help having to repeat myself with certain key points. It would appear that many new candidates tend to make many of the same errors as in the past. The MW practical exam requires multiple disciplines and talents – excellent tasting, excellent communication through the written word and excellent discipline. Not surprisingly, in order to ‘master’ these three key skills, one needs to practice intensively. I think the clearest observation I have to make this year, and Peter also makes this point in his S1A report, is that too many students seem under-prepared. This tends to manifest itself though a number of important areas: time management, concise and relevant answers, accurate tasting and clear understanding of quality.

As the reach of the Institute continues to grow, so does the number of students in disparate geographies. It is clear that forming tasting groups in many places is challenging, but it still needs to be done. I am convinced that tasting in small groups is the best (and cheapest!) way to practice. It is certainly not good enough to start your year with the 12 wine blind tastings at the residential seminars. The successful students will have a clear, achievable plan of tastings for each full ‘academic year’. I would certainly suggest doing an average of at least one 12 wine blind tasting a week for the six months before the exam and two a week in the last few months. It is also essential to conduct an honest post-tasting analysis every time, in order to maximise the learning experience. Some may be already doing this, but I fear others are not.

I mentioned in my report last year that having taken a lenient approach to typographical errors in 2016 (the first year of type-written scripts), the examiners would be less forgiving in 2017. I am pleased to report that this has improved significantly although there are certainly a number of

students who are leaving themselves little time to check what they have written. Worse this year was the use of 'cut and paste'. This creates a really bad impression – no two answers should ever be completely the same. On a similar theme, spelling of 'wine words' continues to be poor. This year's examples include 'Sangvioese', 'Cortone Charlemagne', 'Barollo', 'Savienners', 'Savannieres', Pauillac and 'Raix Baixas' to name a few. In each case they were misspelled more than once - they were not typing errors. As a student you would not expect an MW to misspell these – please consider carefully how poor an impression such mistakes make.

Perhaps even more importantly are the theoretical inaccuracies that continue to blight far too many papers. Examples such as 'Brunello de Montalcino, Chianti, Italy', 'Soave, Valpolicella', 'Volnay, Côte de Nuits', 'Douro, Spain' 'Pouilly Fuissé in the Loire' (twice!), Maury with 19% alcohol, and 'Meursault, Grand Cru' among others, again suggest there are too many inadequately prepared students sitting the exam.

I am often asked if such and such an expression or phrase 'is allowed?' My stock answer is to use the same sort of language you might expect a Master of Wine to use; to sound as authoritative and logical as possible. The issue is not normally the language itself, but whether it is appropriate at that moment. A phrase such as 'Purity of fruit suggests New World winemaking' sounds fine, but in fact implies erroneously that the Old World does not produce wines of comparable purity. Such a phrase ('purity of fruit') might be better applied in the quality element of a question. Similarly, whilst the use of the term 'Full-bodied' is of course valid, it has to be applied to relevant wines, not to a Muscadet, as it was a couple of times this year.

Again, as I mentioned last year, a key reason why many of the C+ candidates failed to pass was because they failed to answer too many questions with sufficient depth. Students need to be very mindful of the number of marks allocated to each element of the question. This comes back to practice and timing as I have already mentioned. This should be an area of focus for the MW educators in the coming year.

Last year I wrote 'I would encourage all students to read this report in conjunction with previous reports since the basic principles of success remain the same yet the same shortfalls seem to be evident to a greater or lesser extent every year. These are time management, inability to assess quality accurately within the context of the region from where the wine originates, and an inability to accurately read how a wine style has been achieved by the winemaker, particularly with regard to the use of oak which again was the sole focus of many scripts. Careful consideration also needs to be given with regard to the number of marks available for any given question since this is a clear pointer to the number of observations the candidate needs to discuss.' Exactly the same still holds true this year I'm afraid.

Please may I reiterate the examiners attitude to the use of abbreviations and acronyms. Please keep these to a minimum and to those readily accepted in general writing on wine – such as MLF and pH. Abbreviated names can also be used if introduced in full – Western Australia, WA. However, it is not acceptable to write (as one candidate did) an entire key at the top of each exam for the subsequent use of numerous unusual acronyms. Please also write full sentences where you can – bullet points will not be marked down but it is hard to make a convincing argument using bullet points. I also mentioned last year that we would be testing the ability to take an intelligent stab at vintages from

various 'classic European origins' which we duly did. However, please do not automatically assume the wines concerned are from Bordeaux!

Specific Observations

Paper 1

Question 1.

This was answered very well by the vast majority of students with many correct answers for all three wines which got us off to a good start. An element of repetition is inevitable in questions such as this where the funnelling technique is by far the best method to construct a compelling argument for geographical origin. Having correctly identified the origin there was a real opportunity to score heavily in the remainder of the question but whilst the winemaking element of this question was well answered, only a few candidates discussed the importance of lees. You must also remember to relate commercial arguments back to what you are tasting in the glass. One examiner correctly noted that 'interesting for those nostalgic for their returns to France' was not a helpful answer to the commercial potential for wine 2.

Question 2.

I always struggled to spot Pinot Gris when I was a student, and I don't think this pair was particularly easy, especially given the markedly different style of the two wines. However, where you have more than one wine to help you, one of them will show enough character to open the door. In this case it was the Neudorf example, thanks to its 'purity of fruit' (as mentioned above) which many good students spotted correctly. The quality of the Alsace wine was often over-estimated; the examiners felt that, whilst displaying a clear sense of place, it would not improve further; please do not assume that old world wines will always be the superior examples.

Question 3

This was perhaps the most difficult question in the entire exam. The origin was narrowed down to Italy in the question but of course it is not easy to differentiate between un-oaked Italian whites, even characterful and correct examples such as these. However, only the best candidates made intelligent guesses on possible origins, based on their theoretical knowledge of the options, using logical evidence from the glass as back-up. We did not expect candidates to get these wines spot on, what we did expect were answers that showed good understanding of Italian white wine styles. Even if you struggled with origin, you still had the chance to pass this question, with 13 marks up for grabs on style and quality. This should have been relatively straightforward for well-prepared candidates. How to maximise points on apparently difficult wines should be a focus in the future – see also Paper 2 Wine 12.

Question 4

This question also proved difficult with very few candidates correctly identifying all three varieties. That in itself was not a disaster as long as answers remained logical. Unfortunately many of the winemaking answers were just trotted out without reference to either the wine or its possible origin.

The best answers linked the winemaking to the climate and location, which was the intention behind the question.

Question 5

Pleasingly, a large number of candidates correctly spotted both the Meursault and the Chablis which is to be applauded. Perhaps they intelligently took a big clue from the question relating to the vintage. The best answers went to Burgundy early in their argument and then used their theoretical knowledge of Burgundy to argue the correct origin. Those who did will have scored highly. When discussing vintage, it is important to show logical consideration of all the possible vintages to construct a suitably strong argument. The use of oak was well answered here but it must be remembered to also highlight other key elements of winemaking in this sort of question.

Paper 2

Question 1

The best answers made a balanced argument for Cabernet Sauvignon across all four wines highlighting all the classic elements of the variety whilst showing intelligent consideration to what it might have been, but was not. Constructing this sort of argument takes practice and it was clear that all the weaker answers resulted from a lack of practice. There is a theme emerging here....

Having correctly identified Cabernet Sauvignon, the best candidates went straight to Bordeaux for wine 1 then argued for a specific origin from there. This was a good approach since the examiners were looking for the candidate's detailed knowledge of Bordeaux with this wine. Many correctly went to the Left Bank but from there many arguments fell apart. You could get very high marks without identifying St Estèphe, but you did need to show authority in considering the appellation options. Wine 2 was often correctly spotted as a modest Australian example – quality was important here. Winemaking dominated Wine 3 – one had to consider possible origins where a wine of this 'extreme' style is likely to be made. Examiners were lenient in their marks, but it was alarming to see suggestions of Margaret River or Gimblett Gravels in this case. Meerlust Rubicon clearly showed a sense of place and good candidates focussed on the nature of the tannins when suggesting South Africa. The quality and maturity elements of this question were just as important as origin – and only a few candidates were confident and experienced enough to get anywhere close on the 1996 Montrose.

Question 2

Thankfully, Italy was the choice of the vast majority of students and many wrote convincing answers to all four wines suggesting that there is a good level of knowledge in this area. Students should be reminded that valuable marks are lost if a wine's quality is not put within the context of its origin when this is what is asked for. One examiner remarked that 'Few candidates did this but rather opted to assess the intrinsic quality in isolation.' The Chianti was particularly well answered in this respect, less so the other three wines. This again suggests a lack of knowledge of various regions in Italy and perhaps a lack of practice in answering this sort of question.

Question 3

The last four wines were often well answered - the good tasters came to the fore here. Quality assessments were less impressive with many inflating the quality of the Pinotage in particular. The Lagrein was very difficult but many had an intelligent stab at it and will have received good credit for a logical argument. The quality of the German Pinot Noir was clearly appreciated by all the students although hardly anyone suggested it might come from Germany.

Paper 3

Question 1.

Rosé wines have not been well handled in past papers and I can sympathise here since I too used to struggle with this style. I am happy to report however, that 2017 was a watershed in this regard, with the vast majority of students scoring heavily in this question. Not only was the origin answered accurately, with well backed up arguments, but the commercial element of the question proved a success. This was good news all round and certainly contributed to Paper 3 achieving the highest average mark across the three papers this year.

The simple, slightly confected character of the Sutter Home Zinfandel was picked up as was the high residual sugar. The occasional student let themselves down with an inaccurate and illogical assessment of the alcohol. The dry delicacy of the Provence example was also noted accurately. Many candidates put the Pelorus Rosé in Champagne but the arguments were often logical and still gained good marks.

Question 2.

I have to confess to being a little nervous about this question as we do not often put singleton wines in the exam. However, well prepared students answered this question with good authority. The best answers were confident enough to address the obvious use of skin contact and slightly oxidative style. Many suggested the quality was very good, which was fine as long as it was backed up accurately. There was an element of subjectivity about the quality of this wine and so the examiners took a relatively lenient stance on this section of the question.

Question 3.

Whilst the Giesen Riesling was correctly assessed, including its lowish alcohol, by many students, the Husch Gewurztraminer was not. Accurate assessment of residual sugar remains a problem and candidates must remember to always link commercial potential to what they are tasting in the glass. Failure to do this cannot result in being awarded full marks even where a decent stab has been made at answering the question.

Question 4.

Syrah was the most popular answer for the two Grenache based wines. This was not a disaster in itself but did serve to allow the really thoughtful and experienced tasters to stand out. Many candidates correctly placed Wine 7 in Australia and Wine 8 in the Rhône, but with the latter they went, of course, to the Northern Rhône. Where in the northern Rhône is going to produce a wine

with the high alcohol and breadth of wine 8? Surely a Languedoc, or other warmer climate, Syrah would have been more logical? We do encourage you to take the obvious option – and Australia / Rhône seemed the obvious Syrah contenders. But did those answers suit the wines before you?

While candidates provided good answers for style and market position of each wine, surprisingly few made the effort to fittingly *compare and contrast* the wines. There was plenty to discuss here and should have been easy marks for the well-prepared candidates. It's important to carefully read and answer the question completely. Again, this comes down to thorough preparation and practice.

Question 5.

I was surprised and disappointed in the number of candidates who put these two Burgundies into Bordeaux. Was this because a vintage was asked for? Of those who were in Burgundy, many gave answers that were let down by either unconvincing arguments or theoretical inaccuracies. One extreme example was the suggestion of a Vosne-Romanée 1er Cru - because it has 'moderate alcohol of 15%'. This totally undermines the confidence the examiner might have had in the candidate. (Further shattered by reading from the same paper 'Douro, Spain' for Vintage Port in the next question).

It is very important to choose relevant and specific adjectives when discussing the detail in the classic regions, but especially Burgundy given its relative subtlety. Many students need to work on this in order to be more convincing and authoritative. The best students looked beyond the oak to differentiate depth of fruit, length and relative development.

Question 6.

Many candidates were pretty accurate on the final pair. The best answers at least considered Palo Cortado for the Sherry and used the subtle presence of flor and relevant structural elements of the wine to arrive at an appropriate origin and style. The same can be said for the Maury although many plumped for Port, missing the lower level of alcohol, not to mention the completely different fruit character of the two wines. However, the key to doing really well in this question was an accurate assessment of the method of production of both wines and this was, unfortunately, very poorly answered. This essentially comes back to the tenor of this entire report, that too many students are poorly prepared, either through lack of tasting experience or through having had an insufficient amount of practice in the run-up to the exam. For example, when assessing the Maury, it was essential to discuss the fortification of the wine and which grape variety was used in its production - two factors completely fundamental to the style. Yet numerous candidate failed to discuss either. Finally, when considering 'who might buy this wine', please consider the various trade channels as well as the final consumer in various geographies.

Conclusion

I apologise if this report has so much that comes across as negative and depressing. The MW Practical Exam is not easy and does require a great deal of experience, knowledge, practice and discipline to achieve the average of 65% to pass. Candidates need to taste consistently well for all three days and complete every question, free from theoretical inaccuracy, arguing clearly and logically throughout. Correct identification of all the wines in the exam is of course most unlikely – it

is essential to pick up good marks on the quality, winemaking and commercial elements of the question when the origin of the wine is unclear. This takes practice, sound exam technique and honesty in your private, post-tasting, analysis. I cannot stress this enough. As I have said before, there are no shortcuts and it is the honest students who really know if they have done sufficient work in the run-up to the exam, who have properly addressed their weaknesses and who will ultimately prove successful.

Finally, I would like to thank my fellow examiners for the huge amount of work they put in when preparing this exam behind the scenes and for giving up a very considerable chunk of their summer to undertake the marking. It is greatly appreciated.